playing golf. Mark was another foodie and I have fond memories of the many fantastic meals we had together in his house in Connecticut in 1998 when I spent a week there. I was totally shocked when I first heard about his fatal car accident at Kharbi, not far from Nagpur in central India in 2002, and must say I lost a very close friend and confidant. We worked wonderfully well together and it is impossible to fill the void created by his untimely death.

After Mark was gone a number of agents approached me and expressed an interest in managing my affairs. However, my relationship with Mark was such that it never occurred to me to leave WorldTel. And I am happy to say I have been proved right, with Vinod Naidu, my current manager and friend, taking care of my affairs for a decade and more, first on behalf of WorldTel and then on behalf of WSG (World Sport Group). I first met Vinod in Sharjah in 1998 and then in London over a delicious lunch at my favourite Thai restaurant, Patara, when Mark introduced the two of us. It was after Mark's untimely demise that Vinod and I started working closely together. We spoke to each other regularly and, like Mark, Vinod soon came to understand and respect my concerns. It was always clear to him that my cricket was my top priority. Between Mark and Vinod, I have been lucky to have two great people to work with. In fact, it would perhaps not be wrong to say that I have spent more days with Vinod than anyone else in the professional realm over the last decade and I have enjoyed every bit of it. Vinod knows me inside out and has been a constant presence whenever I needed him. To spend so much time away from his family in order to manage my interests is evidence of his commitment to his profession, and his is another friendship I deeply cherish.

Pakistan again

The quarter-final against Pakistan on 9 March 1996 was by far the biggest match of the World Cup. There was tremendous security around the team hotel and we knew that the nation would be watching. That was not so unusual for an India–Pakistan match, but the World Cup had added a further dimension to this particular knock-out encounter. On the day of the match we reached the ground early and found the atmosphere at the Chinnaswamy Stadium to be truly unbelievable. The stadium was packed hours before the game and the crowd was loud and boisterous.